UPSC CIVIL SERVICES MAINS | ANTHROPOLOGY OPTIONAL | PAPER I

Topic 6 — Part I
Cognitive Theories: Tyler and Conklin

Exact syllabus wording covered: "Anthropological theories: ... (i) Cognitive theories (Tyler, Conklin)."

What this topic is really about. Every other theory in Topic 6 describes a culture from the outside — its functions, structures, energy flows or symbols. Cognitive anthropology asks a narrower and stranger question: **what does a person have to know to behave as a competent member of this culture, and how is that knowledge organised in their own categories?** It treats culture as a **code held in the mind**, reads that code through **native vocabulary**, and writes it down with **formal methods** borrowed from linguistics. Conklin showed how rich and exact such codes are; Tyler defined the field in 1969 and then walked out of it, which is why this clause hands you a bridge straight into 6-J.

Study window	Opens 10 Nov 2026 — **half a day** (one session), per your Subject Coverage row
Estimated study time	1 hr 30 min first pass, including the 150-word note and one 15-mark answer
Revision time	12 min full note • 4 min one-page sheet (Section 15)
Study as	One idea — culture as cognitive code — plus two exemplars (Conklin, Tyler) and one ledger of criticism. Learn Fig. 1 and Fig. 3 cold.
Note status	Draft 1 — for your review. Not final until you sign it off.
Boundary	Emic/etic as Harris's epistemology is **6-G** (done). Geertz's public-meaning culture is **6-H**. Sapir–Whorf and linguistic relativity are **Topic 7**. Tyler's postmodern turn is developed in **6-J**.

Candid verdict — the lowest-frequency clause in Topic 6, and cheap to secure. Only **two** stems in the record name it: **1996** ("What is cognitive approach? Critically examine its implications...") and **2002** ("Write a note on Cognitive Anthropology"). Nothing since — **24 years dormant**, and absent from every paper from 2013 to 2026. Your tracker rates it Mains Value **High** on a PYQ count of 2; on the count alone it should be **Low**, and I have set it so. Two reasons it is still worth the half-day: a cognitive note is entirely predictable, so it is near-certain marks if it does appear; and its ideas carry weight elsewhere — the **emic** half of Harris (6-G), **Geertz's attack** on it (6-H), the **2025** linguistic-anthropology question (15 marks), indigenous knowledge and **shifting cultivation** in Paper II, and **Tyler's own conversion**, which opens 6-J.

2 SCOPE MAP

What is included

- **What cognitive anthropology is** — its definition, its alternative names (ethnoscience, new ethnography, ethnosemantics), and its two founding questions.
- **Roots** — Boas and Sapir on native categories, Pike's emic/etic, Goodenough's definition of culture, the Yale group.
- **Methods** — elicitation frames, contrast sets, folk taxonomies, paradigms and componential analysis, decision keys.
- **Conklin** — Hanunóo plants, colour categories and swidden agriculture; the birth of ethnoecology.
- **Tyler** — the 1969 reader that defined the field, Koya kinship, and his rejection of formalism.

- **Later phases** — Berlin and Kay's colour universals, folk-biological ranks, prototypes, schemas and cultural models, consensus theory.
- **Criticism** — psychological reality, formalism and narrow domains, Harris's and Geertz's attacks, Tyler's self-critique.
- **Indian material** — Tyler's Koya fieldwork, Dravidian kin terminology, ethnobotany and traditional ecological knowledge, jhum.

What is excluded, and where it belongs

Material	Belongs to	Why it is kept out
Emic/etic as Harris's research strategy; the etic-behavioural cell	6-G, done	Named here as Pike's distinction and the cognitivists' commitment; Harris's use is there
Culture as public symbolic meaning; thick description	6-H	Geertz appears here only as a critic of cognitivism
Lévi-Strauss's unconscious binary structures	6-D, done	One comparison table (11.2), not a re-teach
Sapir–Whorf; nature and origin of language; sociolinguistics	Topic 7	Linguistic relativity is the background, not the clause
Writing Culture, deconstruction, the crisis of representation	6-J, next	Tyler's turn is named here as the bridge; developed there
Kinship terminology types (Hawaiian, Iroquois, Dravidian)	2.5, done	Componential analysis is the method; the typology is there

How it connects outward

- **6-G** — Harris built cultural materialism partly *against* the "new ethnography". The two clauses are a matched pair: emic-ideational against etic-behavioural.
- **6-H** — Geertz's "Thick Description" (1973) names Tyler as spokesman for what he calls the cognitivist fallacy. Quote it in either clause.
- **6-J** — Tyler edited the cognitive reader in 1969 and wrote the most radical essay in *Writing Culture* in 1986. Use him to open a postmodernism answer.
- **Topic 7** — the 2025 question on theoretical perspectives in linguistic anthropology (15 marks) wants ethnoscience as one of its perspectives.
- **Paper II** — traditional ecological knowledge, shifting cultivation (2022, 15 marks), the Apatani (2024), the Forest Rights Act.

3 PYQ DEMAND AUDIT

Mains

Wording from your 1995–2021 compilation (Vishnu IAS, Unit 6(i)), which records no marks for either year; cross-checked against Edukemy. Full papers for 2013–2026 checked: no cognitive stem appears in any of them.

Year	Question (as recorded)	Demand	Counted
2002	Write a note on Cognitive Anthropology.	Definition plus features — a short note	Yes
1996	What is cognitive approach? Critically examine its implications in Sociocultural Anthropology.	Approach plus critique of its consequences	Yes
2015	Explain the difference between 'Emic' & 'Etic' and how does the difference derive from the study of language? (10)	Pike's emic/etic from phonemics — core 6-I content, filed under Unit 7	Adjacent

Year	Question (as recorded)	Demand	Counted
2025	Describe briefly the theoretical perspectives in linguistic anthropology to explain the relationship of culture, language and thought. (15)	Ethnoscience is one of the perspectives	Adjacent
2020	Sapir–Whorf hypothesis. (10)	Linguistic relativity — the background	Adjacent
2019	Relationship between Linguistics and Social-Cultural Anthropology. (10)	The emic model came from phonemics	Adjacent
2022	Paper II: balance between livelihood and environment in shifting cultivation. (15)	Conklin's swidden rehabilitation	Adjacent

Prelims

Not applicable. The optional is a Mains paper, and GS Prelims has not set ethnoscience or componential analysis. No Prelims facts are carried in this packet.

What UPSC is actually testing

Demand	Times	What is really being tested	Your reading
Define and characterise the approach	2 — 1996, 2002	Whether you can say what makes it distinct: culture as knowledge, read through native categories, written in formal models	Fig. 1 plus 5.1–5.3. Master Answer 1
Its implications, critically	1 — 1996	What changed in ethnography because of it — and what it could not do	5.8 plus 11.1. Master Answer 2
The named scholars	0	Tyler and Conklin are in the syllabus but have never been named in a stem	5.4–5.5. Master Answer 3 skeleton

Trend reading

- **Dormant since 2002.** Every other Topic 6 clause has been set since 2013; this one has not. A return would most likely be a 10-mark note.
- **The names have never been asked.** Tyler and Conklin were added to the syllabus but no stem has used them. Prepare one paragraph on each so that a named question does not catch you out.
- **The ideas travel.** The 2015 emic/etic question (10 marks, filed under language), the 2025 culture–language–thought question and the 2022 shifting-cultivation question all reward a cognitive paragraph. That is where most of this clause's marks will actually come from.
- **Set it Low, revise it briefly.** Two askings, both before 2003, give Mains Value Low. Keep it to a half-day and one recall pass.

4 BIG-PICTURE CONCEPTUAL MAP

MOVE 1 — Culture is knowledge, not behaviour. Goodenough (1957): a society's culture is whatever one has to know or believe to operate in a manner acceptable to its members. Behaviour and artefacts are products of that knowledge, not the culture itself.

MOVE 2 — The knowledge is organised in the people's own categories. Tyler (1969): each culture has a unique system for perceiving and organising things, events and behaviour. So the ethnographer asks two questions — **what matters to them, and how do they organise it?**

MOVE 3 — Language is the way in. Native terms label native categories. Model the description on phonemics: find the contrasts that matter to speakers. This is Pike's **emic** (1954).

MOVE 4 — Write the code formally. Taxonomies give the vertical "kind of" structure; paradigms and componential analysis give the horizontal features that separate terms; keys give decision rules. The aim is a description others can test and replicate. *Fig. 2, Fig. 3*

MOVE 5 — The exemplars and the exit. Conklin showed the Hanunóo code was richer than Western botany. Tyler defined the field and then argued that meaning escapes formal models. The criticisms — psychological reality, narrow domains, culture is public — are where every long answer ends.

That chain is the shape of any answer in this packet: **culture as knowledge → native categories → language as the way in → formal models → exemplars and limits.**

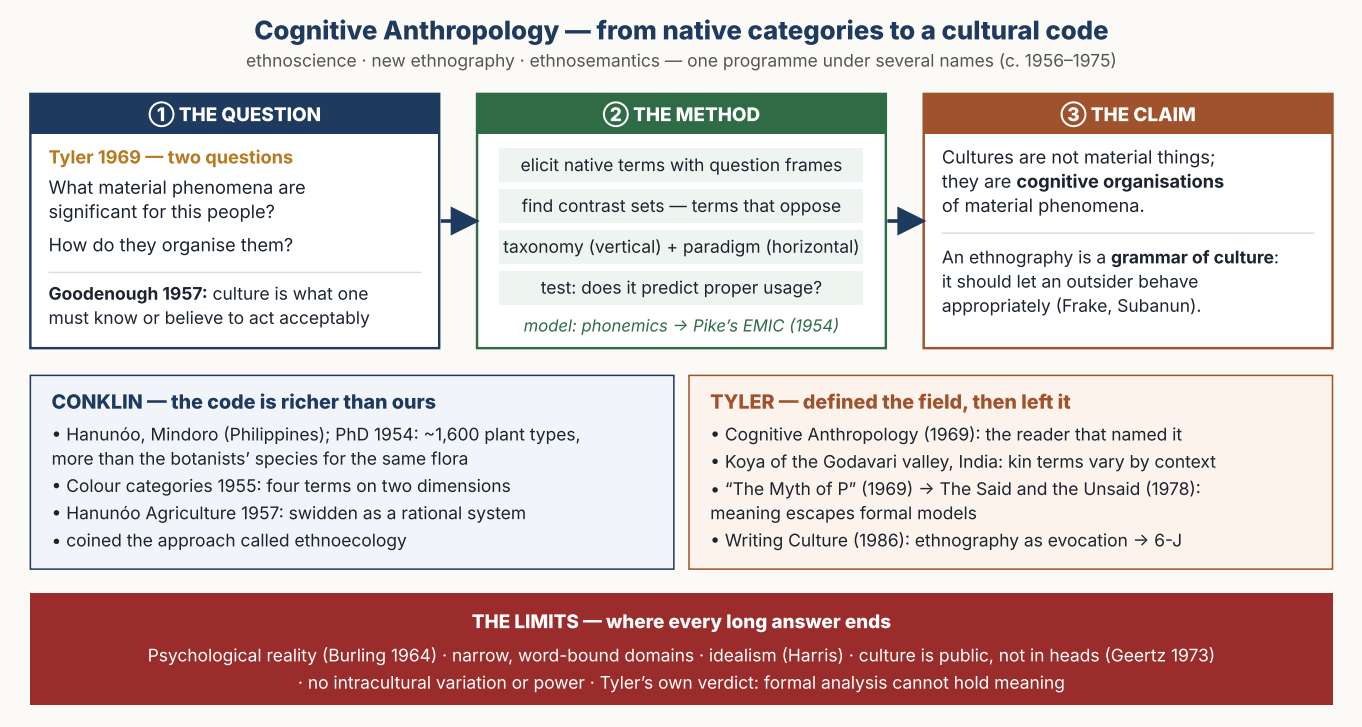


Fig. 1 — the whole clause on one page: the question, the method, the claim, the two syllabus exemplars and the ledger of limits. This is the spine of every answer in the packet.

5 CORE NOTES

5.1 What cognitive anthropology is

Plain version. Cognitive anthropology tries to describe a culture the way its own members carve up the world — which plants are "the same", which relatives are "brothers", which illness is which — and to write that down so precisely that a stranger could use it.

- **Working definition.** Cognitive anthropology is the study of the relation between culture and human thought, which treats culture as a **shared system of knowledge** and seeks to describe it in the **categories and principles of organisation used by its bearers**, usually through their language.
- **Tyler's formula (1969, p. 3).** It asks two questions: **what material phenomena are significant** for the people of a culture, and **how they organise** those phenomena. Cultures, on this view, are not material phenomena but **cognitive organisations of material phenomena**.
- **Goodenough's definition (1957).** "A society's culture consists of whatever it is one has to know or believe in order to operate in a manner acceptable to its members." This is the definition the whole school rests on. MEMORISE
- **Its other names. Ethnoscience** (Sturtevant 1964: the system of knowledge and cognition typical of a given culture), **new ethnography** (Harris's label, used critically), **ethnosemantics**, **componential analysis**, **folk classification**. Use "cognitive anthropology" as the umbrella and give the others once.
- **Where it sits.** It belongs to the **ideational** wing of American anthropology, with symbolic and structural approaches, and against the materialist wing (White, Steward, Harris).

5.2 Roots — where the idea came from

- **Boas and the Boasians** — native categories, language as the key to culture, the "native's point of view". Malinowski's phrase from *Argonauts* (1922) is the same aspiration.

- **Sapir and Whorf** — language shapes habitual thought. Cognitive anthropology took the weaker, testable version: vocabulary reveals what a culture distinguishes. *Topic 7 has the hypothesis.*
- **Structural linguistics** — phonemics finds the few sound contrasts that matter to speakers out of the infinite sounds they make. **Kenneth Pike** (1954) generalised phonemic/phonetic into **emic/etic**: emic units are those significant within a system, etic units are the outsider's cross-cultural grid.
- **Goodenough's move** (1956, 1957) — if language can be described by its emic contrasts, so can culture. Kinship terms were the first test case: his componential analysis of Trukese terms (1956), alongside **Lounsbury's** Pawnee analysis in the same year.
- **The Yale group** — Goodenough, Lounsbury, and the younger cohort of **Conklin, Frake and Sturtevant**, who were graduate students at Yale together in the early 1950s. Conklin and Frake both worked in the Philippines.

5.3 Core propositions and methods

Proposition	What it means	Who
Culture is a code in the mind	Behaviour and artefacts are products of knowledge; the knowledge is the culture	Goodenough 1957; Tyler 1969
Each culture organises the world uniquely	Categories cannot be assumed from the ethnographer's own language	Tyler 1969
Categories are built by contrast	A term means what it is opposed to within its set — the phonemic principle	Pike 1954; Frake 1962
Language is the royal road	Lexemes label categories; eliciting terms reveals the code	Conklin 1962; Frake 1962
Description must be replicable	Formal procedures, so that another ethnographer reaches the same result	Sturtevant 1964
Ethnography as a grammar of culture	A good description lets an outsider behave appropriately — "how to ask for a drink in Subanun"	Frake 1964
Emic description comes before comparison	Cross-cultural comparison is only valid if the units compared are really comparable	Tyler 1969

The tool-kit

- **Elicitation frames.** Controlled questions in the native language — "What is that?", "What kind of X is it?", "Is a Y a kind of X?" — so that the people's own terms and relations emerge. Frake's method in "The Ethnographic Study of Cognitive Systems" (1962).
- **Contrast sets and domains.** A domain is a set of things grouped by a cover term (plants, kin, diseases); a contrast set is the terms at one level that exclude one another.
- **Folk taxonomy.** The vertical structure of inclusion — "a white oak is a kind of oak is a kind of tree is a kind of plant". *Fig. 2*
- **Paradigm and componential analysis.** The horizontal structure: each term is defined by a bundle of **distinctive features** (components). Wallace and Atkins's analysis of English kin terms (1960) uses three dimensions: sex, generation, lineality. *Fig. 3*
- **Keys and decision tables.** Ordered rules for choosing a term, as in Frake's "The Diagnosis of Disease among the Subanun of Mindanao" (1961) — how a Subanun decides which skin disease a person has.
- **Later tools.** Free-listing, pile sorts, triad tests and consensus analysis (Weller and Romney, *Systematic Data Collection*, 1988) — the methods that survived the school.

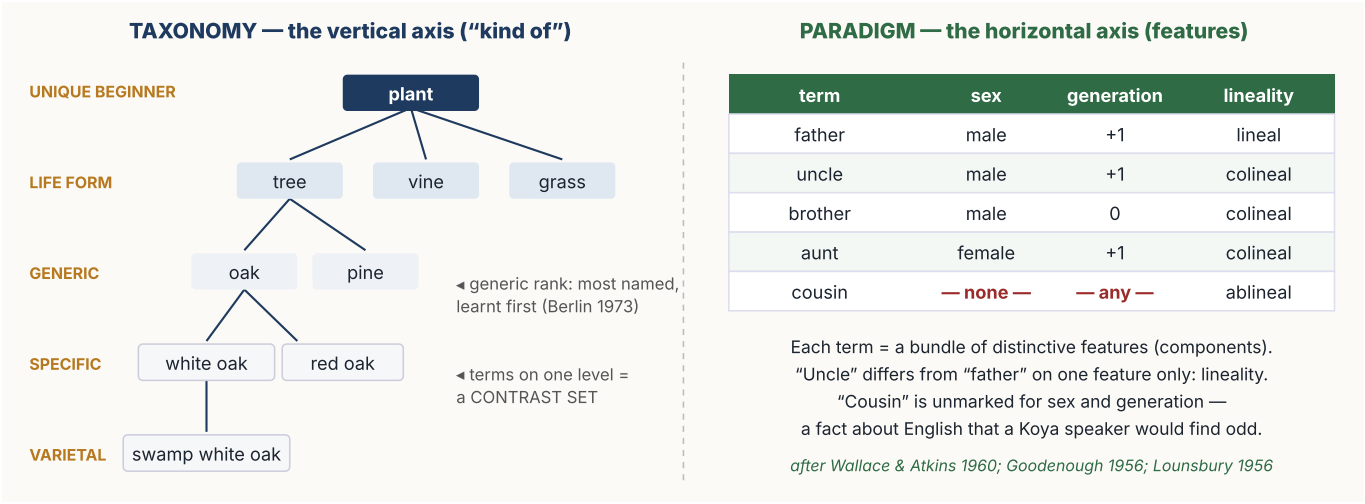


Fig. 2 — the two formal structures of a cognitive description. A taxonomy orders terms by inclusion; a paradigm separates terms on one level by their features. Folk-biological ranks after Berlin, Breedlove and Raven (1973). Draw the right half for any componential-analysis question.

5.4 Harold C. Conklin (1926–2016) — the exemplar of ethnoscience

Plain version. Conklin lived for years with the Hanunóo, swidden farmers of Mindoro in the Philippines, and showed that people Westerners called "primitive slash-and-burn farmers" carried an exact, enormous and logical body of botanical and agricultural knowledge.

- **Who and where.** American, Berkeley then Yale (PhD 1954), taught at Columbia and then Yale. Fieldwork among the **Hanunóo** (a Mangyan group of Mindoro), 1947–58, and the **Ifugao** of Luzon, 1961–73.
- ***The Relation of Hanunóo Culture to the Plant World* (PhD, 1954).** The Hanunóo distinguished about **1,600 plant types** (1,625 in the dissertation count), nearly all of them culturally significant, and their categories **outnumbered the botanists' species for the same flora by more than 400**. This turned ethnobotany from a list of "useful plants" into the study of folk classification.
- **"Hanunóo Color Categories" (1955).** Four basic terms — *(ma)biru* dark, *(ma)lagti'* light, *(ma)rara'* red, *(ma)latuy* light green — organised on two dimensions: **lightness against darkness**, and **dryness against wetness or freshness**. *Rara'* covers maroon, red, orange and yellow — the colours of dried or ripened plant matter; *latuy* covers light green and its mixtures with yellow and light brown — the colours of fresh, succulent growth. A system that looks deficient from a spectral chart is precise once you see it is built for plants. *Fig. 4*
- ***Hanunóo Agriculture* (FAO, 1957).** A report on "an integral system of shifting cultivation": swidden shown as a planned, knowledge-intensive, ecologically fitted system, not a destructive habit. Conklin is credited with the term **ethnoecology** — the study of a people's own understanding of their environment.
- **"Lexicographical Treatment of Folk Taxonomies" (1962).** Showed how to record folk categories in a dictionary: lexeme types, inclusion, contrast. With Frake (1962) this is the method's charter.
- **Later work.** *Folk Classification*, a topically arranged bibliography (1972); *Ethnographic Atlas of Ifugao* (1980), on Ifugao terraced rice fields.
- **Why he matters in an answer.** He is the proof that the method works and that indigenous knowledge is systematic. Every argument for traditional ecological knowledge runs through him.

5.5 Stephen A. Tyler (1932–2020) — the definer who became the critic

Plain version. Tyler collected the field's key papers into one book in 1969 and wrote its definition. Working on kinship among the Koya in India, he found that people use terms in ways no tidy formal model predicts — and over the next decade he concluded that meaning cannot be captured by formal analysis at all.

- **Who and where.** American; UC Davis, Tulane, then Rice University (first chair of anthropology from 1970). Fieldwork among the **Koya**, a Dravidian-speaking tribe of the Godavari valley in Andhra Pradesh, from the early 1960s. *Koya: An Outline Grammar (Gommu dialect)*, 1969; *India: An Anthropological Perspective*, 1973.
- ***Cognitive Anthropology* (ed., 1969).** The reader that gave the field its name and canon. His introduction supplies the two questions and the formula **"cognitive organisations of material phenomena"** (p. 3), and argues that emic description is the precondition for valid comparison.

- **Koya kinship.** "Koya Language Morphology and Patterns of Kinship Behavior" (1965) and "Context and Variation in Koya Kinship Terminology" (1966): the same relative is addressed and referred to differently by context, so **a single context-free paradigm misdescribes usage**. The seed of his doubt.
- **"The Myth of P: Epistemology and Formal Analysis" (1969).** Questioned what formal analyses actually represent.
- ***The Said and the Unsaid: Mind, Meaning and Culture* (1978).** Meaning lies as much in context, intention and what is left unsaid as in the lexicon; the cognitive model of culture as an explicit code is rejected.
- **The turn.** A participant in the 1984 Santa Fe seminar; author of "Post-Modern Ethnography: From Document of the Occult to Occult Document" in *Writing Culture* (1986): ethnography should **evoke**, not represent. *The Unspeakable* (1987). → 6-J
- **Geertz names him.** In "Thick Description" (1973) Geertz calls the view that culture consists of mental phenomena analysable by formal methods "the cognitivist fallacy" and quotes Tyler as its spokesman. A good examiner-pleasing link between 6-I and 6-H.

> **The one line that lifts a Tyler answer.** "Tyler's career is the arc of the school itself: he defined cognitive anthropology in 1969, found in Koya kinship that usage escapes formal paradigms, and by 1986 was arguing that ethnography can only evoke, never represent."

5.6 The wider cast — who to name

Scholar, year	Contribution	Use it for
Kenneth Pike, 1954	*Language in Relation to a Unified Theory of the Structure of Human Behavior*; emic/etic from phonemic/phonetic	Origin of "emic"
Ward Goodenough, 1956, 1957	Componential analysis of Trukese kin terms; culture as what one must know	The definition
Floyd Lounsbury, 1956	Semantic analysis of Pawnee kinship usage	Componential analysis
Wallace & Atkins, 1960	"The Meaning of Kinship Terms": English terms on sex, generation, lineality; raised psychological reality	Fig. 3; the first criticism
Charles Frake, 1961, 1962, 1964	Subanun disease diagnosis; elicitation frames; "How to Ask for a Drink in Subanun"	Method; ethnography as grammar
William Sturtevant, 1964	"Studies in Ethnoscience" — the field's survey and definition	Definition of ethnoscience
Robbins Burling, 1964	"Cognition and Componential Analysis: God's Truth or Hocus-Pocus?"	The decisive criticism
Berlin & Kay, 1969	*Basic Color Terms*: eleven basic terms, an ordered evolutionary sequence	Universals against relativism
Berlin, Breedlove & Raven, 1973	Folk-biological ranks; generic level most salient	Fig. 2
Eleanor Rosch, 1973–75	Prototype theory; basic-level categories	Second phase
Holland & Quinn (eds.), 1987	*Cultural Models in Language and Thought*; schema theory	Third phase
Romney, Weller & Batchelder, 1986	"Culture as Consensus": measures shared knowledge and expertise	Answer to the variation critique
Edwin Hutchins, 1995	*Cognition in the Wild*: cognition distributed across people and tools	Modern descendant
Roy D'Andrade, 1995	*The Development of Cognitive Anthropology*	The standard history

5.7 Three phases — how the school changed

Phase	Character	Names
1 · Ethnoscience, c. 1956–70	Emic, particularist, formal: taxonomies and paradigms of bounded domains; each culture unique	Goodenough, Lounsbury, Conklin, Frake, Sturtevant, Tyler 1969

Phase	Character	Names
2 · Universals, c. 1969–80	The method turned up **cross-cultural regularities** — colour sequences, folk-biological ranks — so relativism gave way to constrained universals	Berlin & Kay 1969; Berlin 1973; Rosch
3 · Schemas and models, 1980s on	From words to **cultural models** and schemas; shared knowledge measured statistically; cognition in practice	Holland & Quinn 1987; Romney et al. 1986; D'Andrade; Hutchins 1995

The irony worth one sentence: **a school founded to prove every culture unique produced anthropology's best evidence for universals.**

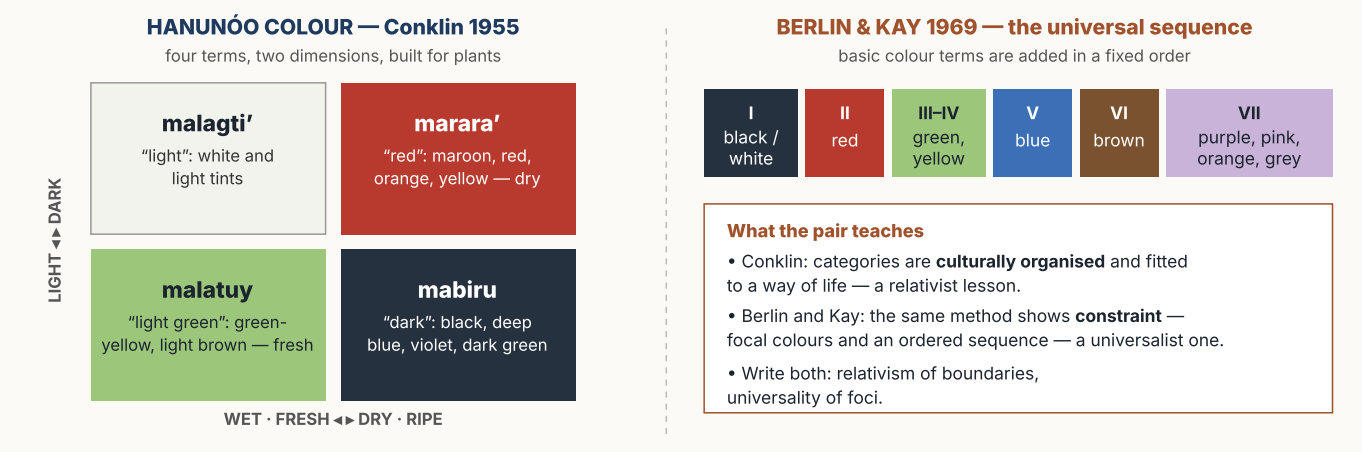


Fig. 4 — Conklin's Hanunóo colour space (left) against Berlin and Kay's sequence (right). Term spellings follow Conklin 1955; the apostrophe marks a glottal stop. Use this figure when a question asks for "implications" — it shows the school producing both a relativist and a universalist result.

5.8 Criticism — the ledger

Criticism	The point	Who
Psychological reality	Several componential solutions fit the same terms equally well; which one is in the native's head? The model may be the analyst's, not the people's	Wallace & Atkins 1960; **Burling 1964**
Formalism and trivial domains	Works for bounded, lexicalised domains — kin, colour, plants, disease — and says little about religion, politics or change	Common verdict; Harris 1968
Lexical bias	Much knowledge is tacit, practical, embodied and never put into words; eliciting terms misses it	Bloch 1991; Tyler 1978
Idealism and no explanation	Describes what people think, not what they do or why; emics without etics cannot explain	**Harris 1968**, "the new ethnography"
Culture is public	Meaning lives in shared symbols and social action, not inside heads — the "cognitivist fallacy"	**Geertz 1973**
Variation and power	Whose categories? A single code hides differences of gender, age, expertise and status	Feminist and practice critics; answered by consensus theory
Static and synchronic	A snapshot of a code says nothing of history or change	General
Elicitation artefacts	The question frame shapes the answer; neat taxonomies may be produced by the interview	Tyler 1966, 1969

The balanced verdict. As a grand theory of culture it failed; as a **method** it survived. Free-listing, pile sorts and consensus analysis are standard in medical, ecological and development anthropology, and the case it made for **indigenous knowledge as systematic** is now policy common sense.

5.9 India — where to use it

- **Tyler among the Koya.** The clause's own named scholar did his fieldwork in India, among the Koya of the Godavari valley, and his evidence against context-free kin paradigms came from Koya usage. Most candidates do not know this; one sentence earns credit.
- **Dravidian kin terminology.** South Indian terms classify relatives as cross or parallel, so a mother's brother's daughter falls into the category of potential spouse. Dumont (1953) read the terminology as an expression of marriage alliance; Trautmann, *Dravidian Kinship* (1981), analysed its logic. The terminology is a classic object of componential analysis. *2.5 has the typology.*
- **Ethnobotany and traditional ecological knowledge.** S. K. Jain of the Botanical Survey of India built Indian ethnobotany on tribal plant knowledge. Policy now records such knowledge: People's Biodiversity Registers under the Biological Diversity Act 2002, and the Traditional Knowledge Digital Library (2001).
- **Jhum.** Conklin's rehabilitation of swidden anticipates the Indian ecological case for jhum in the North-East: P. S. Ramakrishnan's *Shifting Agriculture and Sustainable Development* (1992) on Meghalaya. Use with the 2022 Paper II shifting-cultivation question.
- **Folk illness categories.** Hot/cold humoral classifications of food and illness shape health behaviour; public-health communication works better in local categories. A cognitive point you can bring into medical-anthropology answers.

6 WHAT TO MEMORISE VERSUS WHAT TO UNDERSTAND

Tier	Content
MEMORISE word for word	Goodenough's definition (1957) • Tyler's two questions and "cognitive organisations of material phenomena" (1969) • Pike 1954 emic/etic • Conklin's three works and dates (1954, 1955, 1957) • ~1,600 plant types, more than the botanists' species • the four Hanunóo colour terms and two dimensions • Burling 1964 title • Berlin & Kay 1969, eleven terms • Tyler 1978 and 1986 titles
UNDERSTAND and reproduce flexibly	Why phonemics was the model • taxonomy versus paradigm • componential analysis on English kin terms • why psychological reality is a real problem • why Harris and Geertz objected from opposite sides • how a relativist programme produced universals • why Tyler left • why the method survived the theory
CONCEPTUAL recall only	Lounsbury's Pawnee analysis • Frake's Subanun details • Berlin's five ranks by name • Rosch's prototypes • consensus theory mechanics • Hutchins • the Ifugao atlas

7 HIGH-ROI FACTUAL ANCHORS

Item	What to remember	Why it matters in an answer	Memory hook
Pike, 1954	Emic/etic from phonemic/phonetic	The origin of the inside view	Phone-mic → em-ic
Goodenough, 1957	Culture = what one must know or believe to act acceptably	The school's definition	Know to behave
Conklin, 1954	Hanunóo: ~1,600 plant types, > botanists' species by 400+	Indigenous knowledge is exact	Hanunóo beat Linnaeus
Conklin, 1955	Four colour terms on light/dark and wet/dry	Categories fitted to life	Colours of plants
Conklin, 1957	*Hanunóo Agriculture*; swidden rational; ethnoecology	Paper II jhum	Slash-and-burn is science
Frake, 1961/64	Subanun disease; how to ask for a drink	Ethnography as grammar	Drink rules
Sturtevant, 1964	"Studies in Ethnoscience"	Defines ethnoscience	Ethno + science
Burling, 1964	God's truth or hocus-pocus?	Psychological reality	Whose model?

Item	What to remember	Why it matters in an answer	Memory hook
Tyler, 1969	*Cognitive Anthropology*; two questions; cognitive organisations	Defines the field	What and how
Tyler, Koya	Godavari valley; kin terms vary by context (1966)	Indian link; seed of doubt	Koya context
Berlin & Kay, 1969	Eleven basic colour terms; seven stages	Universals	Black-white first
Geertz, 1973	"Cognitivist fallacy"; quotes Tyler	Public meaning	Not in heads
Tyler, 1978 / 1986	*The Said and the Unsaid*; "Post-Modern Ethnography"	The bridge to 6-J	From code to evocation

8 TECHNICAL VOCABULARY BANK

Term	Simple meaning	Where to use it	Example sentence
Cognitive anthropology	Study of culture as shared knowledge in native categories	Opening any answer	"Cognitive anthropology treats culture as a code rather than as behaviour."
Ethnoscience	A people's own system of knowledge about a domain	Definitions; Conklin	"Hanunóo ethnobotany is ethnoscience at its most exact."
Emic	Distinctions meaningful within the system, to its members	Method; Harris contrast	"An emic description uses the contrasts the Koya themselves make."
Etic	The outsider's cross-cultural categories	Contrast with emic	"The spectrum is an etic grid; Hanunóo colour terms are emic."
Domain	A set of things under one cover term	Method	"Kinship was the first domain analysed."
Contrast set	Terms on one level that exclude one another	Taxonomy	"Oak and pine form a contrast set under 'tree'."
Folk taxonomy	Native classification by inclusion — "kind of"	Fig. 2	"A folk taxonomy is read vertically."
Paradigm	Terms arranged by the features that separate them	Kinship	"English kin terms form a paradigm on sex, generation and lineality."
Componential analysis	Defining terms by bundles of distinctive features	Method; criticism	"Componential analysis reduces 'uncle' to male, +1, colineal."
Elicitation frame	A fixed native-language question used to draw out terms	Frake	"Frake's frames let the Subanun classify their own diseases."
Psychological reality	Whether the analyst's model is what people actually use	Criticism	"Burling showed psychological reality cannot be assumed."
Ethnoecology	A people's own understanding of their environment	Conklin; Paper II	"Conklin's ethnoecology rehabilitated swidden."
Cultural model	A shared, taken-for-granted schema of how something works	Later phase	"Cultural models extended the school from words to reasoning."
Cognitivist fallacy	Geertz's name for locating culture in heads	Criticism; 6-H	"Geertz called it the cognitivist fallacy and quoted Tyler."

9 ANSWER EXPRESSION TOOLKIT

Definitions to reproduce

- **Cognitive anthropology:** the study of the relation between culture and thought, which treats culture as a shared system of knowledge and describes it in the categories and organising principles of its bearers, usually through their language.
- **Culture (Goodenough, 1957):** whatever one has to know or believe in order to operate in a manner acceptable to the members of a society.
- **Ethnoscience (Sturtevant, 1964):** the system of knowledge and cognition typical of a given culture.
- **Componential analysis:** the definition of each term in a domain by the bundle of distinctive features that separate it from the other terms.

Introductions

- (Note) "Cognitive anthropology turned the anthropologist from describing what people do to describing what they must know — and how they themselves organise that knowledge."
- (Critical) "The cognitive approach promised a replicable, insider's description of culture; its implications for ethnography were large, and its limits are as instructive as its achievements."
- (Named scholars) "Conklin and Tyler mark the two faces of the school: Conklin its demonstration, Tyler its definition and its most searching critique."

Analytical and transition lines

- "Phonemics supplied the model: as a language uses a few sound contrasts out of infinite sounds, a culture uses a few category contrasts out of infinite things."
- "A taxonomy is read vertically and a paradigm horizontally; together they are the grammar of a domain."
- "Conklin's Hanunóo distinguished more plant kinds than the botanists who studied the same hillsides."
- "A school founded to prove each culture unique produced anthropology's best evidence for universals."

Criticism and qualification lines

- "Burling's question — God's truth or hocus-pocus? — remains unanswered: several models fit the same terms."
- "Harris objected that it was all emics; Geertz that it put culture in the head. One attacked it from the material side, the other from the symbolic."
- "The method worked best where knowledge is named and bounded, and least where it is tacit, contested or changing."

Conclusions

- "As a theory of culture it was too narrow; as a method it survives in every study of indigenous knowledge."
- "Its lasting gift is the demonstration that 'primitive' knowledge is systematic — the premise of today's respect for traditional ecological knowledge."

India linkages

- Tyler's Koya fieldwork (Godavari valley) • Dravidian cross/parallel terminology (Dumont 1953; Trautmann 1981) • S. K. Jain's ethnobotany • People's Biodiversity Registers (2002) and TKDL (2001) • jhum — Ramakrishnan (1992).

10 DIAGRAM BANK

Figure	Verdict	Use it for	How to reproduce in about 30 seconds
Fig. 1 — the clause in one picture	HIGHEST ROI — draw it	1996, 2002; any framing	Three boxes in a row — question, method, claim — two exemplar boxes below, one red strip of limits
Fig. 2 — taxonomy and paradigm	Draw the right half	Method; componential analysis	A five-row grid: term × sex × generation × lineality, with "cousin" unmarked

Figure	Verdict	Use it for	How to reproduce in about 30 seconds
Fig. 4 — Hanunóo and Berlin–Kay	Draw for "implications"	1996; any critique	A 2×2 of four colour terms on light/dark and wet/dry; beside it a seven-step bar
Fig. 5 — the lineage	Optional	Long answers	A timeline: Pike 1954 → Goodenough 1957 → Conklin 1954–57 → Tyler 1969 → Berlin–Kay 1969 → Holland–Quinn 1987, ending at Tyler 1986

Examiner's-eye view. For a 10-mark note, Fig. 2's grid plus Goodenough's definition and Conklin's plant figure is already a strong answer. What lifts it is one critical sentence (Burling or Geertz) and the Tyler arc.

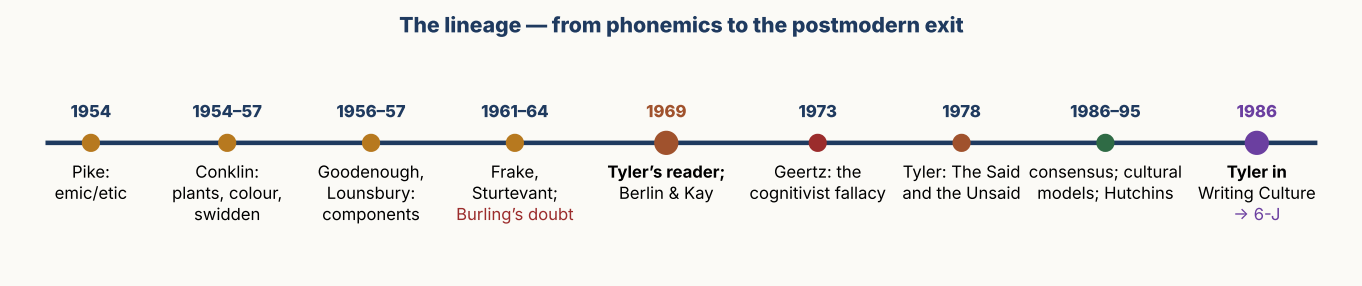


Fig. 5 — the lineage in eight points. Two lines leave 1969: the method continues into consensus theory and cultural models; its definer leaves for postmodernism.

11 COMPARISONS AND DEBATES

11.1 Emic versus etic

Basis	Emic	Etic
Origin	Pike 1954, from phonemic	Pike 1954, from phonetic
Point of view	Insider's distinctions, meaningful within the system	Observer's categories, valid across systems
Validated by	Native speakers' judgements of sameness and difference	Scientific community's procedures
Champion	Cognitive anthropology	Harris's cultural materialism (6-G)
Example	Hanunóo four colour terms	Wavelength, hue and brightness

11.2 Cognitive anthropology versus structuralism

Basis	Cognitive anthropology	Lévi-Strauss's structuralism
Shared source	Structural linguistics: meaning by contrast	
Level sought	Conscious, named categories of one culture	Unconscious structures of the human mind
Scope	Particular — this people's code	Universal — binary logic everywhere
Evidence	Elicited terms, replicable procedures	Myths, kinship, the analyst's reading
Weak point	Narrow domains	Unverifiable deep structures

11.3 Cognitive versus interpretive (Geertz)

Basis	Cognitive	Interpretive
Where culture is	In the minds of individuals, as knowledge	In public symbols and social action
Method	Formal, replicable models	Thick description, hermeneutic reading
Aim	Predict appropriate behaviour	Understand meaning
Geertz's verdict	"The cognitivist fallacy" — with Tyler quoted as its spokesman (1973)	

11.4 Conklin versus Tyler

Basis	Conklin	Tyler
Role	The exemplar: showed the method works	The definer, then the critic
Field	Hanunóo, Mindoro; Ifugao, Luzon	Koya, Godavari valley, India
Domain	Plants, colour, agriculture	Kinship and language
Key works	1954, 1955, 1957	1969, 1978, 1986
Legacy	Ethnobiology, ethnoecology, TEK	Postmodern ethnography; rhetoric and culture

12 MASTER QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

MASTER ANSWER 1 (10 marks, about 150 words). "Write a note on Cognitive Anthropology." (2002)

Cognitive anthropology studies culture as **shared knowledge** organised in the categories of its bearers. Goodenough (1957) defined culture as whatever one must know or believe to act acceptably among a people; Tyler (1969) reduced the task to two questions — **which phenomena matter to them, and how do they organise them**.

Modelled on phonemics and Pike's **emic** (1954), it elicits native terms and writes them as **folk taxonomies** and **componential paradigms**. Conklin showed the Hanunóo of the Philippines distinguished some 1,600 plant types — more than the botanists — and that their four colour terms follow lightness and freshness. Frake's Subanun disease diagnosis showed ethnography as a "grammar" of behaviour.

Critics asked whether such models were psychologically real (Burling 1964), confined to narrow domains, idealist (Harris) or wrongly located in the head (Geertz). Tyler himself turned against formalism. Its methods survive in studies of indigenous knowledge.

About 155 words. Draw Fig. 2's grid in the margin if time allows; cut Frake before cutting the criticism line.

MASTER ANSWER 2 (15 marks). "What is cognitive approach? Critically examine its implications in Sociocultural Anthropology." (1996)

How to structure it. Define through the two questions; give the method in one paragraph with a diagram; then the **implications** — what it changed — and then the **critical** half; close on the balance.

The cognitive approach, or **ethnoscience**, treats culture not as behaviour or artefacts but as the **knowledge** people need to act appropriately (Goodenough 1957). Tyler (1969) framed it as two questions: what phenomena are significant for a people, and how do they organise them? Cultures are thus **cognitive organisations of material phenomena**.

Method. Borrowing from phonemics and Pike's emic/etic, the ethnographer elicits native terms through question frames, groups them into domains and contrast sets, and writes them as taxonomies (inclusion) and paradigms (distinctive features). Componential analysis defines "uncle" in English as male, first ascending generation, colineal.

Implications. First, it gave ethnography **rigour and replicability**: two observers should reach the same description. Second, it took the **insider's view** seriously, which Conklin used to show that the Hanunóo recognised about 1,600 plant types, more than the botanists, and that their swidden farming was a rational system (1957). Third, it made comparison honest — units compared must be emically equivalent. Fourth, unexpectedly, it found **universals**: Berlin and Kay's colour sequence (1969). Fifth, it founded ethnobiology and the study of traditional ecological knowledge.

Critique. Several models fit the same data, so their **psychological reality** is doubtful (Burling 1964). It worked only on bounded, named domains such as kinship, colour and plants. Harris called it idealist — emics without explanation; Geertz called it the "cognitivist fallacy", since meaning is public. It ignored variation and power within a culture, and Tyler, who had defined it, concluded that meaning escapes formal analysis (1978).

As a theory of culture it was too narrow; as a method it endures, and its demonstration that indigenous knowledge is systematic now underpins policy, from biodiversity registers to the recognition of jhum.

About 330 words — right for 15 marks; for 20, add Fig. 4 and one sentence on consensus theory. The "implications" paragraph is what most answers skip.

MASTER ANSWER 3 (15 marks) — skeleton. "Discuss the contributions of Tyler and Conklin to cognitive anthropology." (predicted)

- **Open:** the two faces of the school — Conklin its demonstration, Tyler its definition and critique.
- **Conklin:** Hanunóo plant world 1954 (~1,600 types; > botanists by 400+); colour categories 1955 (four terms, two dimensions); *Hanunóo Agriculture* 1957 (swidden rational; ethnoecology); folk-taxonomy lexicography 1962.
- **Tyler:** *Cognitive Anthropology* 1969 (two questions; cognitive organisations; emics before comparison); Koya kinship 1965–66 (context and variation); "Myth of P" 1969; *The Said and the Unsaid* 1978; "Post-Modern Ethnography" 1986.
- **Draw:** Fig. 4 for Conklin; the Fig. 5 timeline for Tyler's arc.
- **Assess:** Conklin's legacy — ethnobiology and TEK; Tyler's — the critique that meaning is contextual, which Geertz and the postmodernists extended.
- **India:** Tyler's Koya; jhum and Ramakrishnan.
- **Close:** between them, the method's promise and its limit.

13 MAINS QUESTION BANK

#	Question	Marks	Tags
1	Write a note on cognitive anthropology.	10	H R D S
2	Ethnoscience.	10	R S
3	Componential analysis.	10	R D
4	Explain the difference between emic and etic, and how it derives from the study of language.	10	H R S
5	Folk taxonomy with an example.	10	D S I
6	What is the cognitive approach? Critically examine its implications for socio-cultural anthropology.	15	H R D S
7	Discuss the contributions of Tyler and Conklin to cognitive anthropology.	15	R S I
8	"Culture is what one must know to behave acceptably." Examine this view.	15	S
9	Compare the cognitive and interpretive approaches to culture.	15	S
10	How did ethnoscience contribute to the understanding of indigenous ecological knowledge?	15	S I
11	Describe the theoretical perspectives in linguistic anthropology on culture, language and thought.	15	H S
12	"A relativist programme that discovered universals." Discuss with reference to colour classification.	20	D S

H = asked or near-verbatim • R = high ROI • D = needs a diagram • S = needs a scholar or ethnographic case • I = needs an India linkage.

14 CLOSED-BOOK RECALL DRILL

Core concepts (5)

- State Goodenough's definition of culture word for word.

Comparisons (3)

- Cognitive anthropology against structuralism on four bases.
- Cognitive against interpretive, with Geertz's phrase.

- Give Tyler's two questions and his formula for what cultures are.
- Explain emic and etic and where the words came from.
- Distinguish a taxonomy from a paradigm, with one example each.
- Do a componential analysis of "father", "uncle" and "cousin".

Factual anchors (5)

- Name Conklin's three Hanunóo works with years.
- How many plant types did the Hanunóo distinguish, and against what?
- Give the four Hanunóo colour terms and the two dimensions.
- Who wrote "God's Truth or Hocus-Pocus?", when, and about what?
- Where did Tyler do fieldwork, and what did it show about kin terms?
- Conklin against Tyler on role, field, domain and legacy.

Critical judgement (2)

- Give six criticisms with a name attached to at least four.
- Explain in two sentences why the method outlived the theory.

Diagram reproduction (2)

- Draw Fig. 1 from memory with all three columns and the limits strip.
- Draw the Hanunóo 2×2 and the Berlin–Kay seven-step bar.

Timed notes (2)

- In eight minutes, write the 150-word 2002 note.
- In eighteen minutes, write the 1996 answer. Count the named scholars.

15 ONE-PAGE QUICK-REVISION SHEET

THE SPINE

Culture is **knowledge**, not behaviour (Goodenough 1957). Read it in **native categories** — Tyler's two questions: what matters, how organised (1969). **Language** is the way in; phonemics the model (Pike's emic, 1954). Write it **formally**: taxonomy (vertical), paradigm and componential analysis (horizontal), keys. **Conklin** proved it — Hanunóo plants, colours, swidden. **Tyler** defined it, then left it. **Limits**: psychological reality, narrow domains, idealism, culture is public. Method survives; theory does not.

ESSENTIAL TERMS

ethnoscience • new ethnography • emic / etic • domain • contrast set • folk taxonomy • paradigm • componential analysis • elicitation frame • psychological reality • ethnoecology • cultural model • cognitivist fallacy

ESSENTIAL CASES

Hanunóo plants (~1,600) • Hanunóo colours (biru, lagti', rara', latuy) • Hanunóo swidden • Subanun disease and drinking • English kin terms • Trukese, Pawnee kin terms • Koya kinship • Berlin–Kay colours • Ifugao terraces

ESSENTIAL SCHOLARS

Pike 1954 • Goodenough 1956/57 • Lounsbury 1956 • Conklin 1954/55/57/62 • Wallace & Atkins 1960 • Frake 1961/62/64 • Sturtevant 1964 • Burling 1964 • Tyler 1969/78/86 • Berlin & Kay 1969 • Geertz 1973 • Romney et al. 1986 • Holland & Quinn 1987 • D'Andrade 1995

THE THREE LINES TO HAVE WORD-PERFECT

- 1. A society's culture consists of whatever one has to know or believe in order to operate in a manner acceptable to its members. (Goodenough)
- 2. Cultures are not material phenomena; they are cognitive organisations of material phenomena. (Tyler)
- 3. A school founded to prove every culture unique produced anthropology's best evidence for universals.

DIAGRAM CUES

Fig. 1 question → method → claim, exemplars, red limits strip • Fig. 2 kin-term grid with "cousin" unmarked • Fig. 4 Hanunóo 2×2 beside the Berlin–Kay bar.

THE INDIAN SET TO HAVE READY

Tyler among the **Koya** (Godavari valley) • Dravidian cross/parallel terms (Dumont 1953; Trautmann 1981) • S. K. Jain's ethnobotany • PBRs (2002), TKDL (2001) • jhum (Ramakrishnan 1992).

CONFUSIONS TO AVOID

- Stephen **Tyler** (cognitive, 1932–2020) is not Edward **Tylor** (evolutionist, 6-A). Spell it right.
- Emic/etic is **Pike's**; Harris used it, he did not coin it.
- Cognitive anthropology is not structuralism: conscious and particular, not unconscious and universal.
- "New ethnography" is Harris's critical label, not the school's own banner.
- Conklin worked in the **Philippines** (Hanunóo, Ifugao), not in India.

16 SOURCES AND HONEST CAVEATS

What this note was built from

- **UPSC syllabus** — Paper I, clause 6(i).
- **PYQs** — your 1995–2021 topic-wise compilation (Vishnu IAS): Unit 6(i) lists 2002 and 1996, and Unit 7 holds the 2015 emic/etic question; Edukemy lists as a cross-check; full Paper I texts for 2013–2026 checked (Vaids ICS compilation; Mrunal and iasexamportal for 2026). None of the 2013–2026 papers has a cognitive stem.
- **Standard sources** — Tyler (ed.), *Cognitive Anthropology* (1969); Goodenough (1956, 1957); Conklin (1954, 1955, 1957, 1962); Frake (1961, 1962, 1964); Sturtevant (1964); Wallace and Atkins (1960); Burling (1964); Berlin and Kay (1969); Berlin, Breedlove and Raven (1973); Geertz, "Thick Description" (1973); Harris, *The Rise of Anthropological Theory* (1968); D'Andrade (1995).
- **Biographical checks** — National Academy of Sciences memoir of Conklin and RAI obituary; Rice University records for Tyler.

Where you should be careful

- **PYQ wording is compilation-based**; your compilation records no marks for 1996 or 2002. Years and demands are reliable.
- **The PYQ count is 2.** Your tracker had Mains Value High on that count; I have set it to **Low**. If your own audit holds pre-1995 askings, tell me and I will revise.
- **The Hanunóo plant figure varies by source** — 1,625 (dissertation count), "over 1,600", and in one later summary 1,800 plant terms. Write "about 1,600".
- **Colour-term spellings** follow Conklin 1955; textbooks drop the prefix *ma-* and the glottal stop. Either form is acceptable.
- **Geertz's "cognitivist fallacy" passage** quotes Tyler; the phrase is reliable, but paraphrase the rest rather than quoting it at length.
- **The Koya location.** Tyler's Gommu-dialect Koya are a Godavari-valley people of undivided Andhra Pradesh; Koya also live in Telangana, Chhattisgarh and Odisha. "Godavari valley" is safe.
- **Indian applications are illustrative.** PBRs, TKDL and jhum studies are not "cognitive anthropology" in the 1960s sense; present them as the policy descendants of its claim about indigenous knowledge.